

10.2.1.1 The Optimize Palette—A Guided Tour

We'll start right at the top with this one. The first two options on the Optimize palette are Preset and Format. Under Format, you can choose to optimise the image for JPEG, GIF, PNG-8 (That's the PNG format that supports 256 colours), PNG-24 (which supports 16 million colours) and WBMP—a black-and-white bitmap meant for older mobile phones.

For each format, ImageReady comes with its own set of presets. More often than not, these are quite enough for a good size/quality balance, but it never hurts to tinker and see what could help you achieve a lower file size.

Expand the Colour Table pane by clicking on the arrow next to it. You'll see a drop-down menu for Reduction. This is the algorithm that ImageReady uses to decide where it should preserve colour variations and where it should approximate them to a single value. The Perceptual and Selective algorithms are the best, as they give priority to colours that the human eye has greater sensitivity to.

The Colours drop-down lets you select how many colours will be there in your colour table. For images with a few solid colours (like logos which have around three colours and so on), you can safely pull this down to even 16 colours. Of course, this is going to cause the colours to degenerate a little, so use this carefully. 256 colours will naturally give you the best quality, but also the largest size.

If any of the colours in the colour table are within close range of Windows' default colour table for the Web, you can set a tolerance to "snap" to that colour—that is, if the colour in the image's colour table is within, say 5 per cent of the Windows colour, it will use the Windows colour in the table instead. You can view the colour table by clicking on the button next to the Colours drop-down.

Your colour table isn't always going to contain all the colours necessary to reproduce the image, so to simulate these colours, you can use *Dithering*.